War Dogs (Group 6): Speaker Script

MCCJ 527 | 10-minute group presentation | 6 members × 2 slides × ~50 seconds each

Tips: *Text in [square brackets] is a stage cue, not something to say aloud. Each slide is about 110–130 words, roughly 50 seconds at a calm pace. Practise once with a timer.*

MEMBER 1 – Roll 27 – [Your Name]

Slide 1: Title: War Dogs – when organized crime wears a polo shirt (about 50 seconds)

[Hold up a phone or point at the screen.] What does a gangster look like? Most of us picture The Godfather: a dark suit, a family, guns and loyalty.

Now imagine two young men in polo shirts in Miami, sitting at a laptop, bidding on US Army contracts on a public website. Within a few years, they win a contract worth almost 300 million dollars to arm the Afghan National Army, and then end up in federal court.

Good morning. We are Group 6, and our film is War Dogs, from 2016. Our argument today is simple: organized crime does not always carry guns. Sometimes it sells them, with a government contract.

Slide 2: War Dogs at a glance (about 50 seconds)

Some quick facts. War Dogs was directed by Todd Phillips, the director of The Hangover, and released by Warner Bros. in August 2016. It stars Jonah Hill as Efraim Diveroli and Miles Teller as David Packouz, with Bradley Cooper as a mysterious arms broker.

It is a crime comedy, but it is based on a true story, first reported by journalist Guy Lawson in Rolling Stone and later in his book, Arms and the Dudes.

[Right panel.] The central theme is the grey zone where business, the state and crime overlap. The title itself means people who profit from war without ever fighting. And the real contract was worth 298 million dollars.

[Member 2] will take you through the plot.

MEMBER 2 – Roll 8 – [Your Name]

Slide 3: The plot in five moves (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 1]. Here is the plot in five moves.

One: David, a broke massage therapist, joins his childhood friend Efraim's company, AEY. They bid on the "crumbs" of military procurement: small contracts the big firms ignore.

Two: a shipment of pistols gets stuck in Jordan, so they fly out, use local fixers and drive it into Iraq. The money starts flowing.

Three: they meet Henry Girard, an arms broker on a terrorist watch list, who gives them access to 100 million rounds in Albania. They win the Afghan contract.

Four: the ammunition turns out to be Chinese-made, which is banned. Instead of reporting it, they repackage it to hide its origin.

Five: greed and betrayal destroy the partnership. Efraim gets four years in prison, and David seven months of house arrest.

Slide 4: Reel vs real: how much really happened (about 50 seconds)

So how much of this is true? More than you might think.

[Left side.] AEY really did win a 298-million-dollar contract in 2007 to supply the Afghan National Army. Chinese-made rounds really were repackaged to look Albanian. And the sentences are accurate: four years in prison for Efraim, and seven months of house arrest for David after he cooperated.

[Right side.] But some things were changed for drama. Henry Girard is a composite character, inspired by a Swiss broker named Heinrich Thomet. The scary kidnapping-style scenes in Albania did not happen as shown. And the film leaves out something serious: in 2008, an explosion at an ammunition depot in Gërdec, Albania, killed 26 people.

Now [Member 3] will ask the key question: is this actually organized crime?

MEMBER 3 – Roll 37 – [Your Name]

Slide 5: Definitions: the UNTOC test (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 2]. Is AEY really organized crime? Let us test it against the United Nations Convention against Transnational Organized Crime, Article 2. *[Go down the checklist.]*

A structured group of three or more persons: yes. Efraim, David, their financier Ralph, Henry and the Albanian suppliers.

Existing for a period of time: yes, several years.

Acting together to commit serious crime: yes. Fraud against the US government, conspiracy and breaching an arms embargo.

For financial benefit: clearly, yes.

So by the UN definition, AEY is an organized criminal group.

[Right panel.] Three more concepts help us: white-collar crime, crime by respectable people at work; corruption, the abuse of entrusted power for private gain; and state-corporate crime, harm that comes from business and government working together.

Slide 6: Classification: organized white-collar crime (about 50 seconds)

But if we use a criminological definition, the picture changes. Abadinsky lists eight attributes of organized crime. *[Point at the grid.]*

AEY was profit-driven and members had specialized roles, so those fit. Violence, bribery and monopoly only partly fit. But AEY had no hierarchy, no exclusive membership, no code, and it collapsed as soon as its leaders were arrested.

[Right panel.] So we classify AEY as organized white-collar crime: a legal, registered company that used legitimate channels to commit organized, transnational fraud.

And this matters. Because AEY did not look like a criminal organization, nobody checked it closely. [Member 4] will now explain which models describe how it worked.

MEMBER 4 – Roll 33 – [Your Name]

Slide 7: Models: enterprise and network fit best (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 3]. Our course covers four models of how organized crime is structured. *[Go row by row.]*

The hierarchical model of Cressey sees organized crime as a mafia-style bureaucracy. That fits poorly: AEY had no ranks and no code.

The patron–client model of Albini fits partly: Henry acts as a patron who controls access to the Albanian supply in return for a share.

But the strongest fits are the enterprise model and the network model. Smith's enterprise model says legal and illegal business sit on one spectrum and respond to the same market. AEY started legally and slid into fraud as Pentagon demand grew. And Morselli's network model says brokers who connect separate worlds hold the power. Let me show you what that network looked like.

Slide 8: The network: brokers held the power (about 50 seconds)

This is the network behind the deal. *[Trace the orange lines.]*

On one side is the US Army, buying through open online tenders. On the other side is a depot in Albania full of old ammunition. These two worlds could not connect directly. In the middle are the brokers: AEY, with its clean American identity, and Henry, who has the supply but is on a terrorist watch list. Ralph supplies the money, and at the end of the chain are Afghan soldiers, who become the victims of decades-old ammunition.

[Right panel.] This is exactly what Morselli calls brokerage: power belongs to whoever connects worlds that cannot reach each other. And Henry's role shows the crime–terror nexus: someone barred from legal trade simply borrows a clean name.

[Member 5] will explain why they did it.

MEMBER 5 – Roll 24 – [Your Name]

Slide 9: Theories: why they did it (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 4]. So why did two ordinary young men commit fraud on this scale? Four theories from our course help explain it.

Rational choice theory: when they found the ammunition was Chinese, they weighed a contract worth hundreds of millions against a small chance of getting caught. They chose the money.

Strain and institutional anomie: David is broke, with a baby on the way. In Merton's terms, he "innovates". And Messner and Rosenfeld would point out how money overrides family: he keeps lying to Iz.

Differential association: David learns both the techniques and the excuses from Efraim.

And techniques of neutralization: "the troops still get working bullets", and "the government buys from shady sources too". They never see themselves as criminals.

Slide 10: Corruption: Klitgaard's formula and state-corporate crime (about 50 seconds)

But this was not only about two individuals. The system made it possible. Robert Klitgaard gives us a simple formula: corruption equals monopoly, plus discretion, minus accountability.

[Point to each box.] Monopoly: brokers like Henry control the only access to cheap stockpiles. Discretion: contracting officers and foreign officials make decisions with little scrutiny, and fixers move shipments through Jordan. And accountability is low: in wartime urgency, a company run by a man in his early twenties passes the Pentagon's vetting.

[Bottom line.] This is what criminologists call state-corporate crime. The harm came from a government policy of outsourcing war to the lowest bidder, not just from two rogue young men.

[Member 6] will give our final evaluation.

MEMBER 6 – Roll 21 – [Your Name]

Slide 11: Evaluation: strengths and weaknesses (about 50 seconds)

Thank you, [Member 5]. So, is the film accurate or exaggerated? Our answer: accurate in substance, exaggerated in style.

[Left.] Its strengths: it breaks the mafia stereotype and shows crime as a business, with a website and invoices. It matches the enterprise and network models closely. Its characters never see themselves as criminals, which is very realistic. And the core facts are true.

[Right.] But it has weaknesses. As a comedy, it glamorizes the money and makes fraud look harmless. Some characters and dangers are invented. Most importantly, it blames two individuals and underplays the system that allowed the fraud. And it leaves out real victims, including the 26 people killed in the Gërdec explosion in Albania.

Slide 12: Conclusion and questions (about 50 seconds)

To conclude. *[Read the headline slowly.]* Organized crime doesn't always carry guns. Sometimes it sells them, with a government contract.

War Dogs shows that AEY meets the United Nations definition of an organized criminal group, even though it looks nothing like the mafia. The enterprise and network models explain it best, and Klitgaard's formula shows how a weak system made it possible.

And there is a lesson for Bangladesh too. Our large public procurement projects also rely on intermediaries. Vetting contractors, disclosing who really owns a company, and checking where goods come from are not bureaucracy; they are crime prevention.

Thank you. We are happy to take your questions.